

Besides dipping mercury levels, nip in the wind, and the end-of-the-year holiday cheer, December is also Zero1 Awards season as we like to refer to it around the Digit Test Centre. All through the year, through a range of comparison tests and bazaar reviews, not to mention online reviews and DGT pages, all of us reviewers in the team have tested and rated just under 500 products in 2014. In the process, we've dished out numerous Best Buy, Editor's Picks and Best Performer Awards through all 12 issues of Digit magazine this year. However, this award right here – take a look at the trophy alongside – is even more exclusive and elusive than all the rest, because it's a carefully selected compilation of the best performing products of this year. Each and every single one of these winning products represent nothing but the pinnacle in their respective categories' performance standards. That's what Digit's annual Zero1 Awards are all about. What matters? Performance, performance, and only performance! What doesn't? In the wise words of Metallica, "Nothing else matters."

All the various categories of products we test and write about – month in, month out – are represented in this year's Zero1 Awards. We've added a few new categories this year, reflecting the changing trends: Wearables is in, despite being a young segment; so are Mini PCs, and Hybrid Laptops – perhaps the category that exploded the most with a whole host of products, after Mid-Ranged Smartphones around the 15k mark (which is also represented this year). Through the pages of DGT this year, we got to try our hand at some not-so-regular category of products – like high-end luxury watches, motorbikes and even expensive cars (Lamborghini Huracan and BMW Mini Cooper, anyone?). But again, we are only coming to grips with this hitherto uncharted territory, and it's too early to start giving away Zero1 Awards to them just yet.

A lot of care and effort has gone into selecting the product categories for Zero1 Award to ensure we have reviewed enough products in all these categories to be absolutely sure about our stand, and pick the best performing product (aka Zero1 Winner) in all of them through a series of industry-standard benchmarks and unbiased subjective tests. Through the pages that follow, you will see us summarizing the highs and lows of a Zero1 Award product category in the introduction of their respective pages, trying to give our readers an idea of what transpired in that product category this year, and predict future trends (if any). Not just crowing the Zero1 Award winner, we also list out 2-3 products that came close to winning but missed out narrowly – because, hey, just because they didn't win doesn't make them unworthy of your consideration. Remember, any product mentioned or written about in the Zero1 Awards pages are all outstanding products of the year. This is our effort to inform our readers about not just the absolute best performing products in their respective categories but to also give them other products to mull over, products that possess a unique trait or two. Needless to say, if they weren't special, they wouldn't be featured in the pages of Zero1.

Since October, the team has been inundated with a constant influx of devices and have seen enough of them to the extent of even dreaming about them in their sleep. Yep, that's what happened to a team member who shall remain nameless. Many thanks to all the brands who participated in Zero1 Awards automatically by sending us products throughout the year. Congratulations to all the winners! For all those products who came short and missed out on the coveted prize, better luck next time.

Here it is then. Team Digit is proud to announce the winners of the Zero1 Awards 2014. These are the best performing products of this year. Read away!

– Jayesh Shinde

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